

Here's something that could terrify the paranoiacs: in 2003, the British government published a dossier on Iraq's security and intelligence organisations, which was cited by Colin Powell in his address to the UN the same month. Dr Glen Rangwala, a lecturer, discovered that much of the material in the dossier had been plagiarised from a US researcher on Iraq.

The following is some of what appeared in the metadata for that file, which the British government published as an MS Word document on their Web site:

Rev. #1: "cic22" edited file

"C:\DOCUME~1\phamill\LOCALS~1\Temp\AutoRecovery save of Iraq-security.asd"

Rev. #3: "cic22" edited file

"C:\DOCUME~1\phamill\LOCALS~1\Temp\AutoRecovery save of Iraq-security.asd"

Rev. #5: "JPratt" edited file "A:\Iraq-security.doc"

Rev. #6: "ablackshaw" edited file "C:\ABlackshaw\Iraq-security.doc"

Rev. #7: "ablackshaw" edited file "C:\ABlackshaw\A\Iraq-security.doc"

Rev. #10: "MKhan" edited file "C:\WINNT\Profiles\mkhan\Desktop\Iraq.doc"

Notice the names? P Hamill, J Pratt, A Blackshaw, M Khan! Of course, your documents probably aren't as sensitive as those published by the British government, but they could be sensitive nevertheless.

5.3.2 Metadata In Word

Taking Word as an example, the metadata contained in a document includes your name and initials, your organisation name, the name of your computer, the name of the network server or hard disk where you saved the document, the names of previous document authors document revisions and versions, template information, hidden text, and comments!